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Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 6 Wangeci's Story: A Widow Among Women

Cūcū also told me to stay in the house while I was having *mambura* [menstruation]. So I stayed there, and when *Cūcū* noticed that I was not moving out she came and asked me why and I told her. She told me not to go anywhere until the bleeding had stopped. There was nothing we used to cover ourselves with—no cloth—so we just sat on a stool, bleeding. The stool on which one sat while menstruating was not kept in the open where anybody could sit on it because it was considered unclean [contaminated]. Because I did not have my father, there was a hole dug for me to sit over as with other girls. I was with my mother only, so the other children did not know what was happening. When it was finished, *Cūcū* fetched some water for me from the river and after washing myself and my clothes. I washed the stool and then threw it under the bed where it was kept. Afterwards, I was given oil to apply to my body, and that day I spent at home. The following day, I could go out and visit my friends.

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I started to take care of myself where men were concerned. *Cūcū* and my mother had told me not to move with men, because now a man might spoil me for nothing and then I might end up being a *mūkoma ndi* [unmarried pregnant woman] if I got pregnant while at my father's place. Then I would never have the chance of being someone's first wife.

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It was during this time of being young circumcised women that we began to make ourselves more beautiful. When we were younger, we had had our two bottom teeth cut out with a knife and stick once the new ones grew in. Now we would file the upper ones, curving them to make them look better. We would also make these marks you see here [short, dark vertical lines on the cheekbones—cicatures] with a razor and then put in soot from a cooking pot. Also we put marks on the breasts because we used to dance half-naked, and our breasts were very straight and so they were beautiful when we danced. We never thought of ourselves as "naked." Even now, women go about naked because of the dresses they wear that show their legs.

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The marks on our breasts were made using the inside of the maize stalk that covers the kernels. A small piece was cut and one side was covered with saliva to make it stick to the upper part of the breast here. Then the other side was lit with fire and when it healed it left a raised place. Yes, it was painful, but you did not feel it so much because you wanted it done to look beautiful.

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During this time we were going to dances. We would spend the day dancing and even we could decide to spend the night at a *thingira* and nothing would happen. We would go to the *thingira* of a *mwanake kiumbi* [a handsome, well-liked young man]. Before we went there we would tie our clothes with a rope. We would get one edge of the skirt at the front and tie it between the legs and round each thigh with the rope—that way you were protecting yourself. We would spend the whole night at this young  145 man's house being turned over by him on the bed. He would only touch our breasts and nowhere else. At times, we would be so many on the bed that the man would ask his friend to come and help. But if we disliked the friends, we would not let him touch us. The *mwanake kiumbi* was the one who was a good leader in songs, who was the best dancer, had a nice voice, and cracked a lot of jokes, and was handsome. When we went to that man's house, we would never go back home until very early in the morning. The mothers would not see us at all—that was our way of giving them respect.

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